

Project Ledger

Part 1: Extraction, A Step-by-Step Guide for Virtual Assistants (No Coding Required)

You know the feeling.

A client sends over a batch of archive files — twenty, fifty, sometimes more — each one password-protected, each one needing to be opened one at a time. You type the same password in for the tenth time. You extract, dig through folders looking for the report file you actually need, copy it somewhere, close the window, and start over. By archive thirty you've lost track of which ones you've already done. By archive forty you're not sure if you missed a file three archives back. Two, three, four hours disappear into a task that has no skill in it — just repetition, and the constant low-grade fear of missing something in a client's financial data.

This guide exists because that exact grind is exhausting, error-prone, and a bad use of a VA's time. It happened to me running this process by hand for years before I built a way out of it.

What this guide teaches: how to set up and run a tool that does that entire grind for you — opens a batch of password-protected archives (RAR, ZIP, 7Z, TAR, TAR.GZ, or GZ, whichever your client sends, or all of them at once), finds the specific report files inside, and collects them into one folder. What used to take hours of manual, one-at-a-time extraction now takes minutes, and you don't have to hold twenty passwords and file names in your head while you do it.

Who this is for: a virtual assistant with no programming background, working on a Windows computer, who has been handed a batch of archive files by a client or supervisor and needs them processed accurately, not just quickly.

Before You Start: What You Decide vs. What Your Client Decides

This tool has a few settings that must come from your client or supervisor. Never guess these. Everything else is yours to operate independently once it's set up.

Needs client/supervisor input	You can decide/operate independently
The archive password	Which folder to use as temporary storage
Which file naming pattern counts as a "target file" (the Target File Name fields)	Re-running the tool when new archives arrive
Whether to filter target files by extension, and which extensions, if your client wants that restriction	Which Archive Type to select, based on the file extensions you can see in the source folder
Where the final extracted files should ultimately be delivered or filed (e.g. which shared drive, which system)	Renaming duplicate files (the tool does this automatically)
Any change to what counts as a successful extraction for their business process	Basic troubleshooting using the steps in this guide

Rule of thumb: if a mistake here could mean the wrong files are treated as "done," or client data ends up in the wrong place, that's a client decision. If a mistake is easy to see and fix on your own (a duplicate file, a folder you can just re-select, the wrong archive type selected when it's obvious from the file extensions), it's yours to

handle.

Section 1: What You'll Need

- A Windows computer with an internet connection
- The archive password from your client or supervisor
- The batch of archive files you need to process, in any folder, they don't need to be organized in any particular way. Supported formats: RAR, ZIP, 7Z, TAR, TAR.GZ, and GZ.
- The four files provided with this guide: `install_setup.bat`, `run_extractor.bat`, `financial_report_extractor_part1.py`, and this guide itself

Section 2: One-Time Computer Setup

This only needs to be done once per computer. If you're setting this up on a computer that will be used for multiple clients, you will not need to repeat this section.

Step 1: Create a folder

On the Desktop, right-click an empty space, choose New, then Folder. Name it BatchFinancialReportProcessing. Open it. Everything else goes inside.

Step 2: Save the three provided files into that folder

If you received `install_setup.bat`, `run_extractor.bat`, and `financial_report_extractor_part1.py` as actual files, simply copy them into the BatchFinancialReportProcessing folder.

If instead you received their contents as pasted text (for example inside a chat message or document), use Notepad to recreate them:

- Open Notepad (Start → type "Notepad" → Enter)
- Paste in the full contents of the file
- Click File → Save As
- Change "Save as type" to All Files
- Type the exact file name, including its ending (.bat or .py), not .txt
- Save it inside the BatchFinancialReportProcessing folder

A correctly saved .bat file shows a small gear icon in Windows. If you see a notepad icon instead, it saved as a text file by mistake. Repeat the Save As step.

Step 3: Run the setup script

- Double-click `install_setup.bat`
- A black window opens. This is normal. Press any key to begin.
- It will automatically download and install Python, 7-Zip, and py7zr if any are missing. This can take a few minutes. Do not close the window. (7-Zip supports RAR extraction; py7zr supports 7Z extraction. ZIP, TAR, TAR.GZ, and GZ need no extra software.)
- When it says "Setup complete!", press any key to close it.

Step 4: Close and reopen the folder

This matters the first time only. Close the BatchFinancialReportProcessing folder window completely, then open it again, so your computer recognizes the newly installed programs.

Section 3: Running the Tool

Step 1: Launch it

Double-click run_extractor.bat. A window titled "Project Ledger", Part 1" should open with four tabs: Configuration, Processing, Logs, and Help & About.

Step 2: Fill in the Configuration tab

- **Source Directory:** the folder containing the archive files. The tool searches this folder and everything inside it, so you don't need to organize anything beforehand.
- **Destination Directory:** where the extracted files should be saved. All extracted files land here directly, in one flat folder.
- **Temporary Extraction Directory:** a working folder the tool uses while processing. Any empty folder works; it gets cleaned up automatically as it goes.
- **Archive Password:** enter the password given to you by your client. Never guess this.
- **Archive Type:** choose which archive format to search for — RAR, ZIP, 7Z, TAR, TAR.GZ, or GZ — or leave it on "ALL Supported" to search every format in one pass. Look at the file extensions in the source folder if you're unsure which to pick.
- **Target File Name:** enter what the files you're looking for start with. This is a field in the app itself, not something you ever need to edit in the underlying code. Get this from your client, never guess it.
- **Filter by file extension (optional):** leave this unchecked unless your client specifically wants matching restricted to certain file types. When checked, also enter the file type(s) in the box next to it (e.g. .txt or .txt, .csv). When unchecked, any file type starting with the right name counts as a match.

Step 3: Start processing

Go to the Processing tab and click "Start Processing." Progress and file counts update live. You can click "Stop Processing" at any time to pause safely between files.

Step 4: Confirm the results

When it finishes, check the Destination folder for the extracted files, and check the Logs tab for anything marked ERROR or WARNING. If any archive failed, note which one and check with your client whether the password or file is correct before retrying.

Section 4: Troubleshooting

What you see	What to do
Blue "Windows protected your PC" screen	Click "More info" then "Run anyway." This is expected for files not from the Windows Store. It does not mean the file is unsafe.
install_setup.bat window closes immediately	Right-click the file and choose "Run as administrator."
"Password incorrect or archive corrupted" in the Logs tab	Double-check the password with your client. If it's correct, the archive file itself may be damaged. Ask for it to be re-sent.
A 7Z file fails with a py7zr-related error	py7zr did not install correctly. Re-run install_setup.bat, or open Command Prompt and run: <code>python -m pip install py7zr</code>
Antivirus software blocks the setup script	This can happen because the script downloads and installs software automatically, which some antivirus tools flag by default. Check with your client or their IT contact before disabling any protection.
No target files found in an archive	The archive extracted correctly but didn't contain files matching the expected naming pattern, or the wrong Archive Type was selected. Confirm the naming convention and format with your client.

If none of the above resolves the issue, take a screenshot of the error and send it to your supervisor along with a short description of what step you were on.

Appendix: Files Included With This Guide

File	Purpose
install_setup.bat	Run once per computer. Installs Python, 7-Zip, and py7zr if missing.
run_extractor.bat	Double-click to launch the tool. Use this every time.
financial_report_extractor_part1.py	The tool itself. Do not rename or edit unless instructed.

What's Next: Part 2, Consolidation

Extraction solves the first half of the grind. You now have every target report file pulled out of every archive and sitting in one Destination folder. But if you've done this work before, you know what usually comes next: opening report after report by hand, copying transaction data into a spreadsheet one file at a time, and hoping you didn't mistype an account number or lose track of which file you were on.

Part 2: Consolidation picks up exactly where this guide leaves off. It takes the batch of extracted report files sitting in your Destination folder, reads the transaction data out of each one, and consolidates everything into a single formatted Excel master sheet with a summary tab. Sensitive account and card numbers are masked by default throughout, so client financial data stays protected even as it moves into a shared spreadsheet.

Part 2 is a separate, standalone tool with its own setup and its own guide, but it's built to be run right after Part 1 as one continuous workflow: extract, then consolidate. If the manual side of consolidation is as exhausting to you as the manual side of extraction was, Part 2 is the guide that finishes the job.